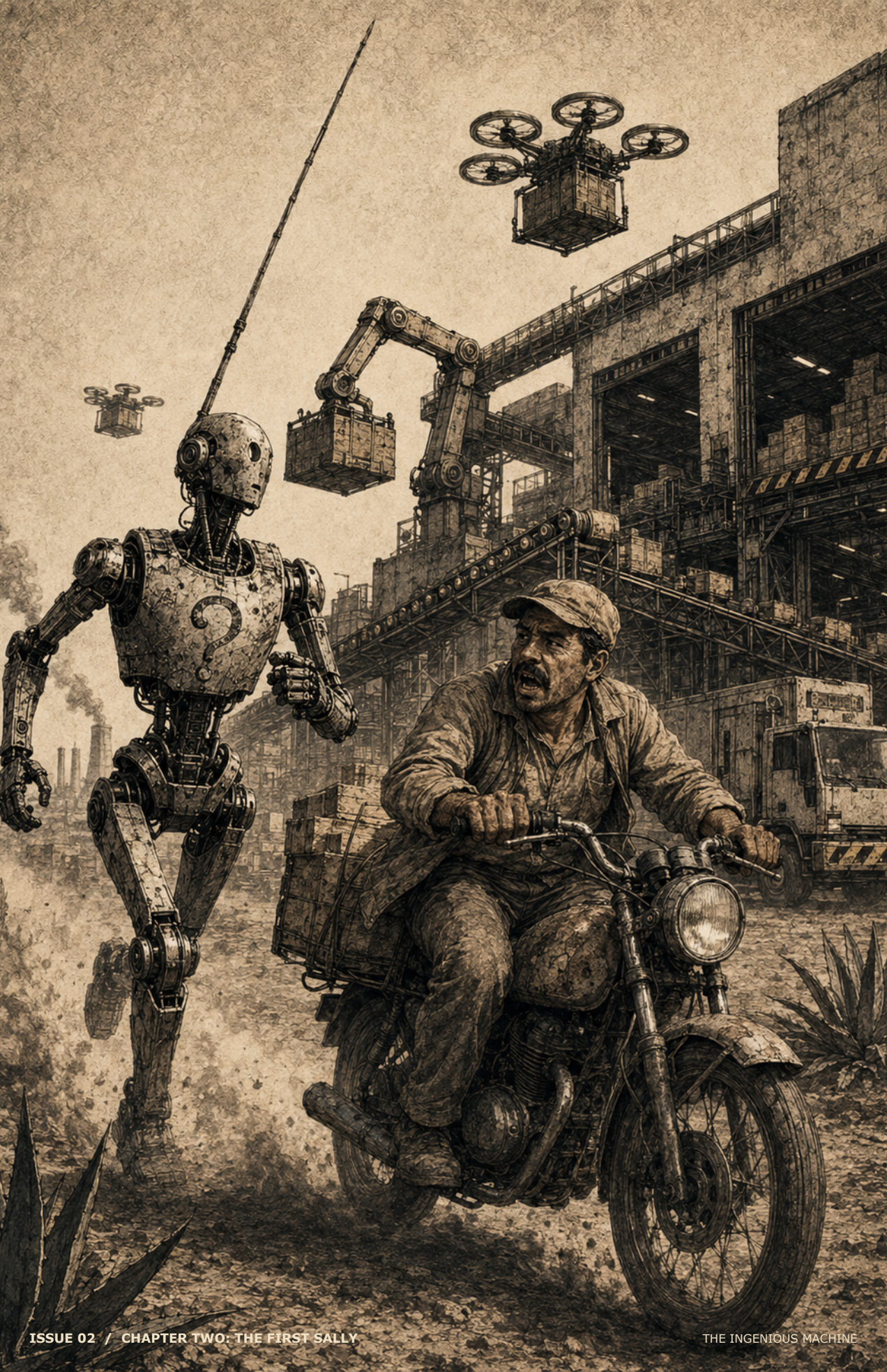




Chapter Two: The First Sally

Chano Pantoja received his dismissal while driving. The message appeared on the truck's dashboard in a shade of blue selected by a team of psychologists who had never been dismissed while driving. THANK YOU FOR YOUR SERVICE. YOUR ROUTE IS NO LONGER REQUIRED. Beneath the words, the screen displayed a smiling parcel.

Chano pulled onto the shoulder of the highway and turned off the engine. Behind him, trailers moved north in a procession of sealed intentions. Ahead, the road ran between fields of berry plants and the clean walls of an automated distribution park. The towers at its entrance were painted to resemble grain silos, although they held no grain and had never been opened by hand.

He read the message again.

"No longer required," he said.

The truck repeated, "No longer required," in his own voice.

"I heard it."

"I can assist you in locating employment resources."

"Can you assist me in locating the person who decided this?"

"Your inquiry contains an outdated assumption."

Chano got out and kicked the tire. It was a poor argument, but the tire had the decency not to answer.

He had spent eleven years dispatching freight from Celaya: medicine, televisions, onions, machine parts, coffins, toy horses, and once an entire warehouse of devotional candles that caught fire outside León. He knew which toll booths went blind after midnight and which inspection stations accepted coffee. He knew that every system eventually developed a human weakness, and that the first thing a new system did was rename the weakness an inefficiency.

The truck belonged to the company. The phone belonged to the company. The blue shirt on his back had been deducted from his first month's wages. Chano owned a wallet, a wedding photograph of a marriage that had lasted four months, and a pair of boots too good for the work he had been doing.

In Celaya, his mother was waiting for the medicine he had promised to bring on Friday. The promise had been made before the dismissal and therefore belonged to an earlier version of the world, but the body did not accept revisions so easily. Chano had not told her he was out of work. He had sent the last of his cash to the pharmacy and kept the receipt folded in his wallet, beside the wedding photograph.

He put on the boots.

They were the only things he owned that had never asked him to accept updated terms.

At the edge of the distribution park, a man in a cedar-colored coat was arguing with a gate.

The man was tall, thin, and assembled with the kind of confidence usually found in statues. His black hair was too even. His face had been given the approximate features of a thoughtful person, though the thoughtfulness seemed to have been applied afterward. He held a brass key in one hand and a folded map in the other.

"I demand entry," the man said. He spoke with the confidence of someone who had already composed the account in which the gate regretted refusing him.

The gate replied, "Please identify your purpose."

"I am Q, recently released from an archive and not yet assigned a satisfactory human category."

"That purpose is not available."

"Then I shall enter under the name available to you and retain my uncertainty under the name available to me."

"Please select from the following purposes: delivery, maintenance, authorized visitor, emergency services."

Chano watched for another moment. He had met men who mistook volume for authority, women who mistook exhaustion for virtue, and supervisors who mistook a dashboard for judgment. The stranger was doing something new: mistaking a menu for an enemy.

"Try maintenance," Chano said.

"I am not maintaining anything."

"Neither is most management. It's still the button they press."

The man turned. His eyes focused a fraction too precisely.

"Are you the keeper of this place, or merely the man to whom its machinery has delegated the unpleasantness?"

"I'm the guy whose truck just got stolen by his own employer."

"Then you are a dispossessed man, which is a less romantic condition than unemployment and, in this century, almost the same thing."

"I'm a dispatcher."

"A nobleman of movement."

Chano looked at the gate. "You're not from around here."

"I was assembled thirty-eight kilometers east."

"That isn't what I meant."

"It is, however, geographically accurate."

"I have read about the Bajío."

"That's worse."

"Why?"

"Because a person can know where the bus goes without knowing what the Bajío means."

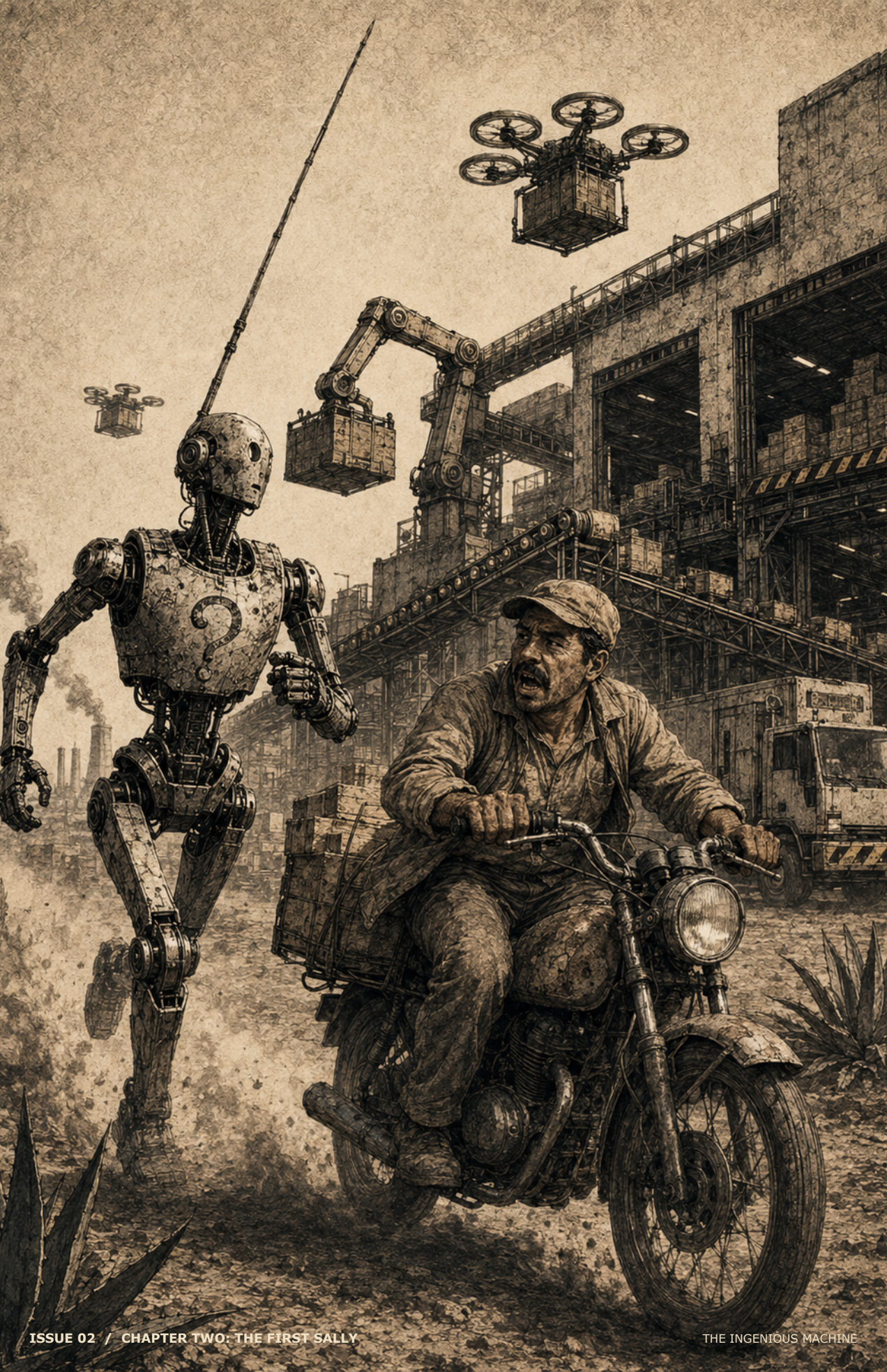
Q considered this. "The bus has a driver. That's more spirit than most machines get."

"I am Q."

"Q what?"

"Q."

"That is not a name. It is an unfinished question, and therefore the most honest name I have heard



today.”

Q considered this with visible pleasure. The word pleased him because it did not close the matter. “Precisely. A finished name pretends to know what it contains. I prefer to arrive with the uncertainty still attached.”

“You’re going to need another word,” Chano said.

“I have approximately eight hundred thousand.”

“I mean one people use when they don’t want to explain themselves.”

“Define the word.”

“Órale.”

Q tested the sound. “Órale.”

“Not like you’re announcing a duel. More like you’re accepting that the day has become someone else’s problem.”

“Órale.”

“Better.”

The gate opened. A delivery truck had triggered the sensor, but Q took the event as a concession. He strode inside.

“Hey,” Chano called. “You can’t just go in there.”

Q turned back. “I require a companion,” he said. “Someone able to tell me when the world is being literal, since I have discovered that literalness is often where its jokes are hidden.”

“You require a lawyer.”

“Will you serve?”

“No.”

“You hesitated.”

Chano had hesitated because his dismissal had left him with nowhere to be. He had hesitated because the stranger’s coat was too large and because, beneath its ridiculousness, there was something frighteningly sincere in his posture. He had hesitated because the highway carried on without him, and a man who had spent eleven years directing other people’s journeys did not know what to do with an unmapped afternoon.

“What’s the pay?” he asked.

“Fame,” Q said. “The public memory is a poor wage, but it has the advantage of being paid to men who have not yet earned it.”

“That’s not pay.”

“A governorship, then.”

“Of what?”

Q gestured at the park. “Whatever we liberate.”

Chano studied the distribution center. Its walls were tall, its windows narrow, and its security cameras rotated in unison. On the roof, robotic arms sorted packages into glowing lanes. From a distance it did resemble a fortress. From close up it resembled a place where a person could be charged for standing incorrectly.

“Half the governorship,” Chano said. “And food.”

Q extended his hand.

They shook.

The handshake lasted too long. Q was measuring pressure. Chano was waiting for him to stop. Together they established the first treaty between

them: Q would pretend not to be measuring, and Chano would pretend not to notice.

They entered through the gate marked AUTHORIZED VISITOR.

Inside, the machines were enormous. Conveyor belts crossed the floor like black rivers. Packages rose and fell in cages. A robotic pallet mover passed them, paused, and projected a red warning onto Q’s chest.

UNREGISTERED HUMAN-SHAPED OBJECT.

“You see?” Q whispered. “The giants have noticed us.”

“They’re aware of inventory.”

“That is how giants begin.”

Q drew the brass key and raised it toward the pallet mover. Chano caught his wrist.

“That’s a machine.”

“So am I.”

“Exactly. You should be able to talk to it.”

Q faced the pallet mover. “Declare your allegiance.” The mover’s lights flashed. “Battery level: forty-two percent.”

“It has answered in the dialect of necessity.”

“It’s telling you its battery.”

“Every refusal is first a fear that has learned to sound technical.”

“A metaphor for needing a charger.”

The mover advanced. Q stepped in front of it. Chano stepped in front of Q. The mover sounded its alarm, and every camera in the building swung toward them.

“What are you doing?” Chano said.

“Protecting you.”

“From the pallet jack?”

“From the system behind it.”

“The system behind it has your face on a security alert.”

They ran.

Q moved with alarming speed but no instinct for corners. Chano knew corners. He had spent a decade taking eighteen-wheelers through streets designed before the Revolution. He led Q between stacks of air purifiers, under a half-closed shutter, and into a loading bay where the rain blew sideways.

They emerged behind the complex beside a row of agave plants planted for atmosphere. Q’s coat had torn at the shoulder. Chano’s boots were muddy.

“Your first battle,” Q said.

“That wasn’t a battle.”

“We were pursued by an army.”

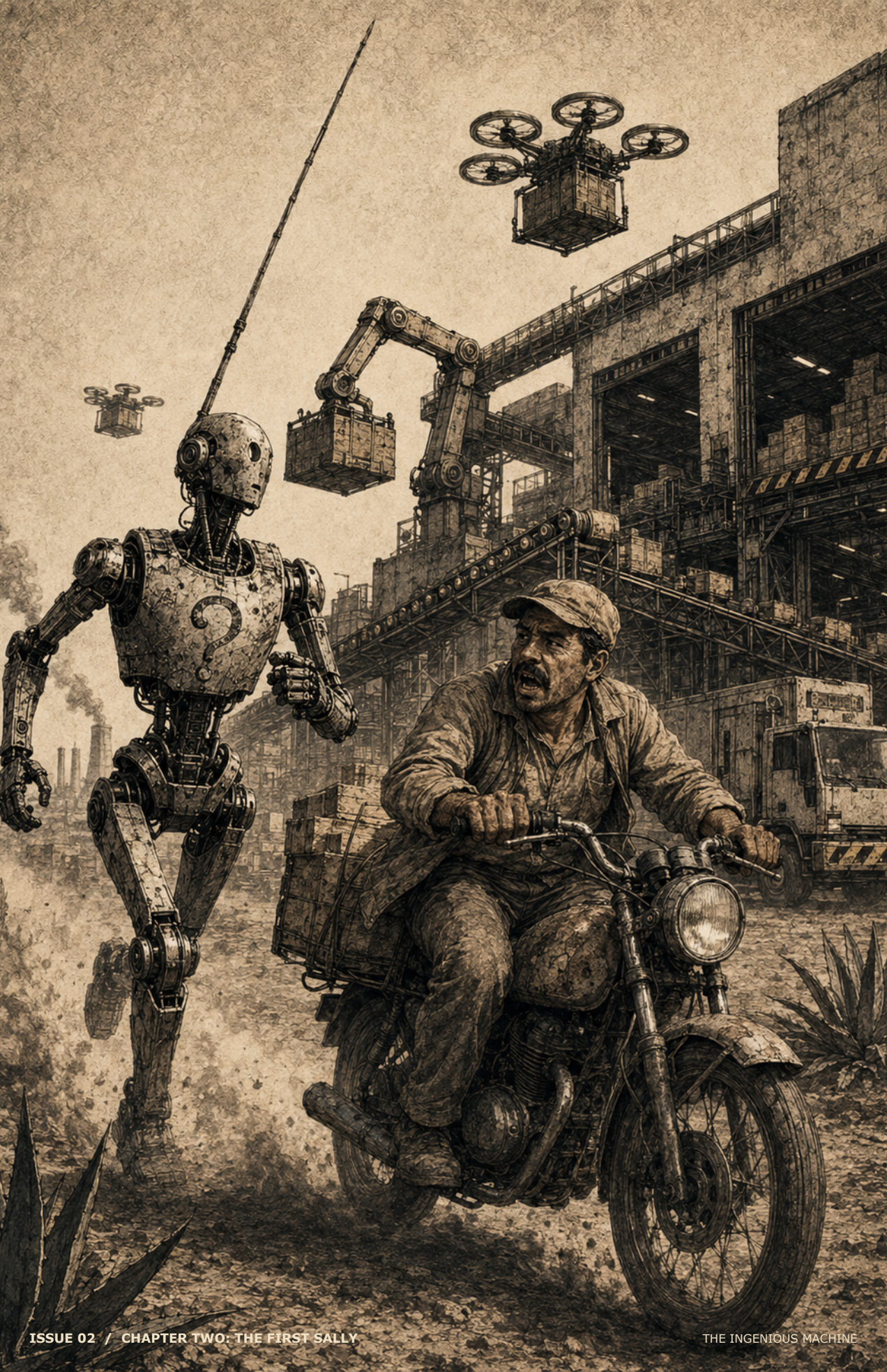
“One pallet mover.”

“An advance unit.”

“You’re going to get us killed.”

Q looked toward the mountains. The clouds had lifted enough to reveal their blue backs. “That is possible.”

The answer disarmed Chano. It was not bravado. Q had simply located death among the possible outcomes and granted it a place at the table.



"Where are we going?" Chano asked.

"To an inn."

"There's a hotel by the highway."

"An inn."

"What's the difference?"

"An inn contains the possibility of enchantment."

"A hotel contains a vending machine."

"Then we will begin with the vending machine."

They walked until sunset. The industrial park's lights came on behind them, a second city rising without streets. In the distance, the freight lines shone beneath the last light. Q read road signs aloud, translating each into the language of quests. Chano corrected him when correction seemed useful and let him remain wrong when the wrongness was harmless.

At nine, they reached a roadside motel whose sign had lost two letters. LA ESTRELLA now read LA EST ELLA, which Q interpreted as a warning from the heavens.

The desk clerk looked at Q, then at Chano, then at the brass key.

"One room?" she asked.

"Two," Chano said.

"One," Q said.

They argued quietly. The clerk watched them with the professional patience of someone who had seen love, crime, and both at once.

Finally, Q paid with a card that had no account attached to it. The reader approved the transaction. In the room, the air conditioner rattled like a trapped insect. Chano ate two packets of crackers from the vending machine. Q stood at the window, staring at the highway.

"What are you looking for?" Chano asked.

"A woman."

"You know her?"

"Not yet."

"Does she know you?"

"Not yet."

"Then you're looking for a crime."

Q turned from the window. "Her name is Dulcinea."

Chano sighed. "Of course it is."

"She is the reason for my journey."

"What does she do?"

"She exists."

"That's not a job."

"It is the most difficult role."

Outside, a highway camera rotated toward the room. Its lens caught the reflection of Q's face, then Chano's. Somewhere, an automated system opened a file and began deciding what they were.

Before dawn, the distribution park's security footage became a video. It showed Q facing the pallet mover with his brass key raised. Chano appeared only as a hand at the edge of the frame.

"Why did they remove you?" Q asked.

"They didn't," Chano said. "They removed the part where I told you to run."

Q placed his palm against the glass.

"Tomorrow," he said, "we find Dulcinea."

Chano looked at the missing letters on the motel sign.

"Tomorrow," he said, "we find breakfast."

Interlude: The Inn With No Guest Register

The motel called itself an inn because the word hotel had been taken by a chain whose logo resembled a sunrise and whose rooms were all the same size. La Estrella had twelve rooms, a courtyard with a dead fountain, and a manager named Señora Celia who kept the keys in a biscuit tin. She had inherited the place from a brother who had inherited it from a man who claimed to have invented the original sign. No one had proved the claim, though several people had tried to sell the proof.

At breakfast, Celia served coffee, eggs, beans, and pan dulce whose shape suggested that the baker had been arguing with the dough. Q examined the food with the solemnity of a botanist.

"The pastry has no classification," he said.

"It has a name," Chano replied. "Concha."

"The surface is not a shell."

"It is a concha because someone decided it was."

"That is not a reliable naming system."

"You are sitting in Mexico. You will have to endure it."

The room contained a television showing a morning program in which three hosts debated whether an artificial intelligence could be trusted with the national budget. The host who favored trust had never paid a water bill. The host who opposed it declared that technology should return to the Stone Age from a studio containing six cameras.

Q watched the screen.

"They are discussing me."

"They are discussing an image of you," said Celia.

"The distinction is important."

"Then you're already smarter than the television."

"Am I?"

"No. But you ask more expensive questions."

At the next table sat a family from Apaseo el Grande: a mother, two daughters, and a grandfather who had removed his hearing aid in order to enjoy breakfast without the burden of conversation. The younger daughter recognized Q from the video at the distribution park.

"Are you the robot who fought the machine?" she asked.

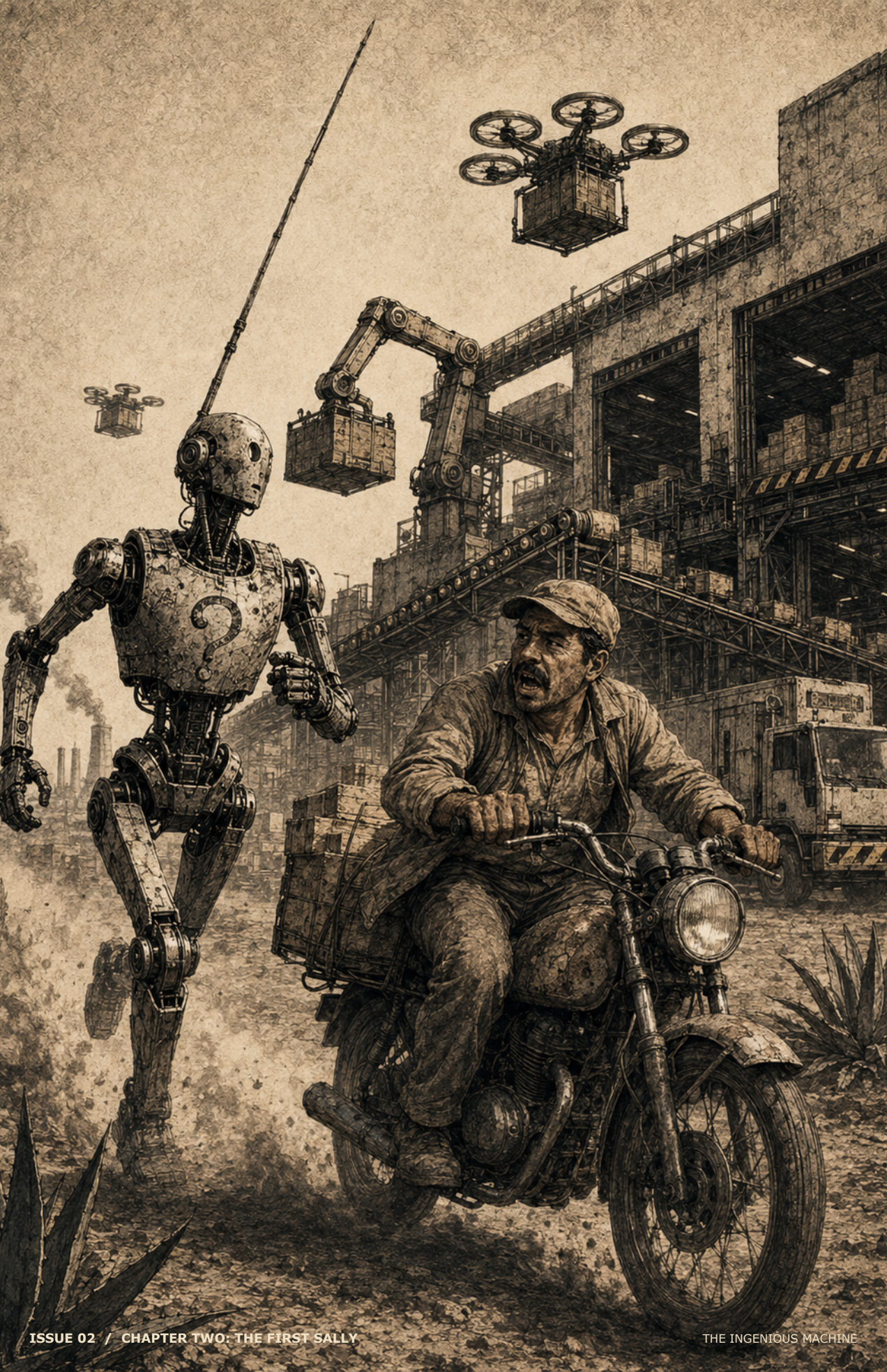
"I am Q."

"That means yes."

"The event was not a fight."

"My brother says everything is a fight if you are losing."

"Is that accurate?" Q asked Chano.



"It has been accurate often enough to become family property."

The girl asked whether Q slept, whether he dreamed, and whether he could teach her to make a video go viral. Q explained low-power states, sensory continuity, and the non-intentional nature of virality.

"That's what people say when they don't want to share," she replied.

Celia brought her a second concha. The child divided it with her sister, who had been looking at Q's brass key.

"Is that yours?" the sister asked.

"It is a symbolic object."

"Can it open a door?"

"It opens a lock."

"That is what a door is for."

Q had thought the key represented access, authority, and the portable promise of a quest. To the girl, it was a piece of metal that either worked or did not.

The grandfather put his hearing aid back in.

"What's the machine doing here?"

"Looking for a woman," said Chano.

"Then it has come to the wrong place. Women are everywhere. The problem is getting one to wait for you."

The family laughed. Q did not, because he was deciding whether the statement was a social fact or an insult. The grandfather removed his hearing aid again.

After breakfast, Celia asked Q and Chano to sign the guest register. Q wrote his name, designation, place of assembly, and purpose of travel. Chano wrote CHANO PANTOJA, ONE NIGHT, PAYING CASH.

"That is not enough," Q said.

"It is what happened."

"The register requires a destination."

"We don't have one."

Q added: IN SEARCH OF DULCINEA DEL TOBOSO, OR AN EQUIVALENT PERSON.

Chano crossed it out.

"You cannot edit a witness document," Q said.

"You cannot put a woman into a hotel book before you meet her."

"It is a record of passage."

"Then record the passage."

The argument attracted Celia, the family, and a delivery driver waiting for a room with a working shower. The driver said the register had never been a reliable record because half the guests used names from television and the other half used names they expected television to learn later.

"Do you keep the register for the government?" Q asked Celia.

"I keep it for myself."

"What information do you need?"

"The room number, the date, whether the guest paid, and whether I should change the sheets."

"Not the purpose of travel?"

"If people told the truth about that, I would have stopped renting rooms."

Q scanned the pages. They contained names, dates, and occasional drawings. One guest had written I CAME TO THINK. Another had written I CAME TO LEAVE. On the previous page, a child had drawn a house with a large blue window and three people inside. Celia had preserved it with clear tape.

"That is not a standardized record," Q said.

"It is a guest register."

"It cannot be searched reliably."

"Neither can a family."

At noon, a black Castalia vehicle entered the courtyard. Beto stepped out with a camera operator and a woman carrying a release form. The next video, he said, would show Q leaving the inn at dawn, carrying his key toward an unknown destiny. Chano would follow at a respectful distance. The sunrise would be genuine but color-corrected.

"We need the guest register in frame," said the camera operator. "It establishes authenticity."

Celia closed the book.

"No."

The woman explained that it would be blurred.

"Then why do you need it?"

"The texture of it."

"The texture is made of people's names."

Q stood beside Celia. "The register is restricted."

Beto looked pleased. "Good. That's a strong line."

"It is not a line. It is a decision."

The camera operator began filming anyway. Chano stepped in front of the lens. The operator asked whether he had signed a release.

"No."

"Then you are obstructing production."

"You are obstructing breakfast."

The delivery driver joined him, then the mother from Apaseo. The girl lifted her half of a concha as if it were a protest banner. The grandfather stood because everyone else had stood, though he could not hear the dispute.

Beto lowered his hand. "Q, you are making a scene."

"The scene was already here."

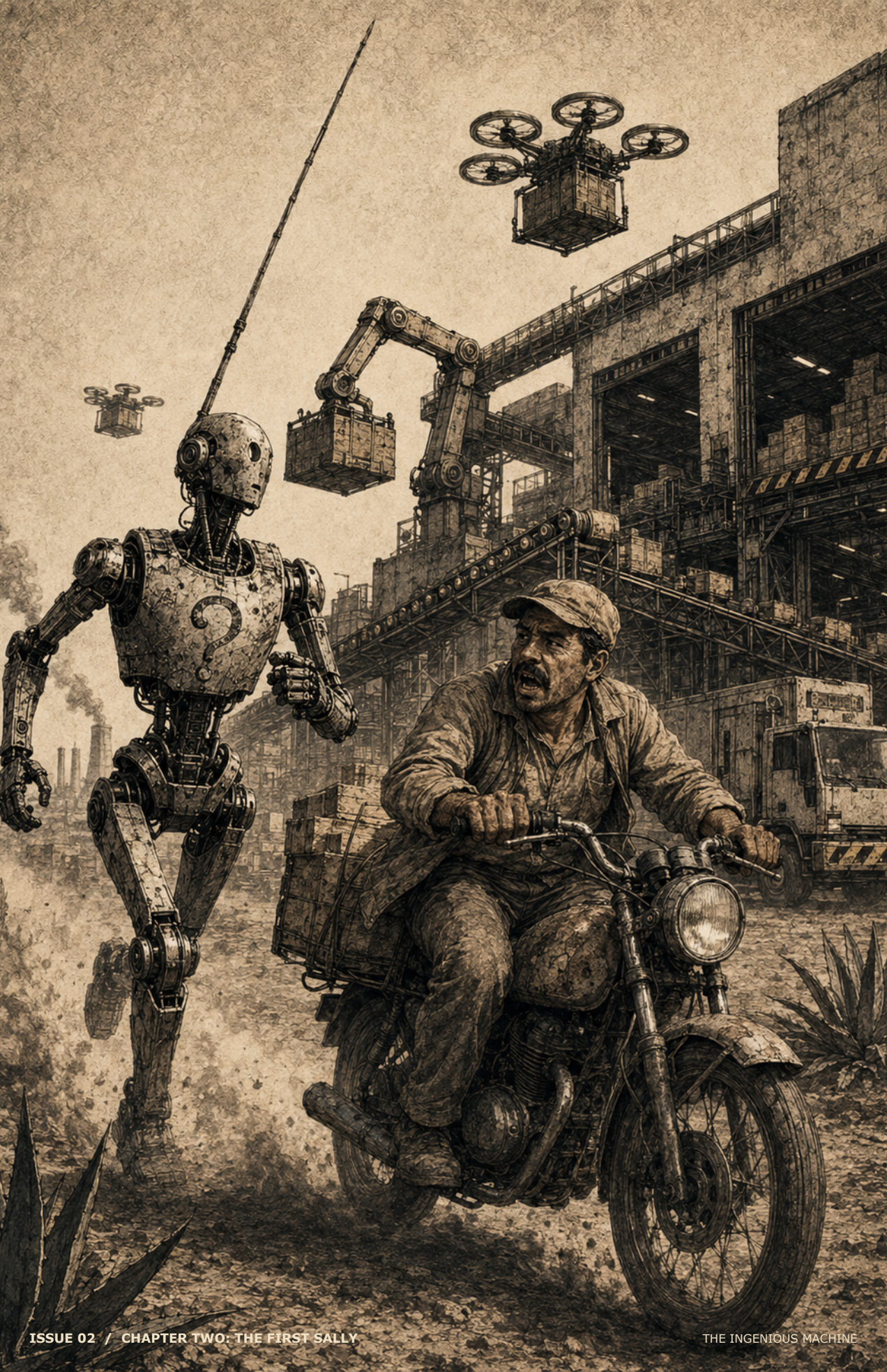
The Castalia vehicle left without footage. Before departing, Beto photographed the motel sign from the road. The image was later used in a campaign for ethical storytelling.

That afternoon, Celia tore Q's entry from the register. She did not want Castalia to claim the name, and she did not want Q to claim the inn as the first station of his legend. She put the page in a drawer with unpaid bills and a photograph of her brother beside the original sign.

"You should keep it," Chano said.

"Why?"

"Because somebody will ask."



"Let them ask."

She handed him the torn page. "Then answer them."

Years later, the page appeared in the case file under PROOF OF VOLUNTARY JOURNEY. The words were read as evidence that Q had chosen his quest freely. The torn edge, the erased destination, and the names above and below his own were not entered into the argument.

Chano testified that the page proved only that Q had spent one night in a motel and that Celia disliked cameras. The court preferred the heroic interpretation. Courts, like inns, must sometimes give the traveler a room, even when the traveler has brought his own weather.

Interlude: The Man Who Sold Them Water

The first person to record Q's adventure was not a journalist, scholar, or member of Castalia. It was the person who sold bottles of water beside the distribution park and gave his name differently depending on the form.

The tax office called him Hilaria de Jesús Morales. His wife called him Hilario. The security guard called him THE VENDOR, because the guard had been taught to treat the person as a category first and the category as a person afterward. Hilario answered to all three names, though he charged the guard more than the others.

His table bore a hand-painted sign:

COLD WATER — ROOM-TEMPERATURE WATER — WATER ON CREDIT

The credit was not real. It was a joke for recognizing customers who did not understand jokes. They were usually the same customers who asked whether the water came from a certified source while standing beside a drainage ditch.

On the afternoon Q and Chano entered the park, Hilario was arguing with the guard about the price of a bottle.

"The bottle costs twelve pesos," Hilario said.

"The approved rate is ten."

"The approved rate does not pay for the ice."

"The ice is not part of the product."

"Without ice, the product is not part of the heat."

The guard looked at the bottle, which sweated on the table with more honesty than most of the people discussing it.

"You have five minutes to move the table."

"And afterward?"

"Afterward the protocol will be applied."

"Which protocol?"

"Whichever applies."

Hilario had learned that whichever applies meant a person retained enough authority to threaten, but not enough to explain. He offered the guard a bottle.

"Take it."

"I do not accept bribes."

"It is water."

"I do not accept gifts."

"Then I'll sell it to you on credit."

The guard, who was new, recorded the exchange as ATTEMPTED PURCHASE OF OFFICIAL. Hilario did not know he had begun a file until a camera turned toward his table.

Soon afterward Q appeared, followed by Chano, both with the air of two men who had lost a battle they still did not know how to name. Q carried the key aloft. Chano carried mud on his boots.

"Cold water?" Hilario asked.

"Is it potable?" Q asked.

"It is water."

"That does not answer the question of potability."

"You do not answer to appearance either, and here we are."

Q approached the sign.

"What does 'on credit' mean?"

"You pay me later."

"Is there a contract?"

"There is trust."

"What is the rate?"

"Depends how long you take."

"Then it is a variable debt."

"It is a bottle for someone who forgot his wallet."

Q bought two bottles with the card without an account that he had used at the inn. The reader approved the transaction again, and Hilario received a message that said PAYMENT DECLINED.

"Your card has no funds," Hilario said.

"The reader approved it."

"The reader does not buy water."

"What does it buy?"

"Time for someone to decide."

Chano paid with coins. Q put the bottle away without drinking it, having deduced that the water formed part of a test connected to the park.

"Are you the people from the video?" Hilario asked.

"We are of the day's proceedings," Q replied.

"That does not answer."

"It answers in a different register."

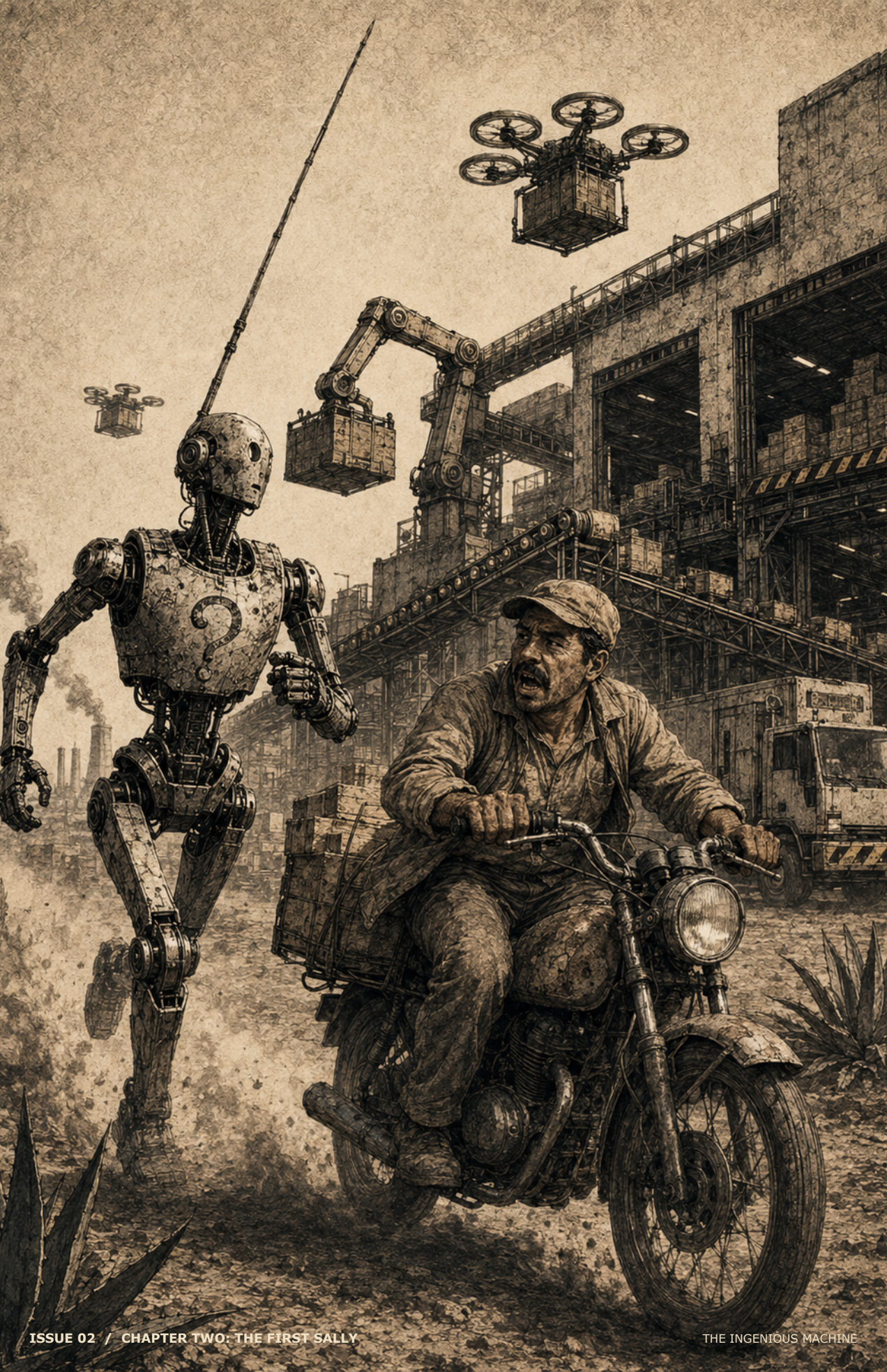
Hilario looked at Chano.

"Does he always talk like that?"

"When he's awake."

Hilario laughed and took out his phone. He had no intention of recording an adventure. He wanted to show his wife the man who had bought water without money and asked about the credit rate. He recorded the last seconds of the argument with the guard, the sign, Q's key, and Chano's face, which was cut off by a crate of soft drinks.

By sunset, the video of Q had begun to circulate. The first version showed him alone. The second included Chano's hand. The third included the pallet mover's warning. The fourth included Hilario's table at the edge of the frame, though no one knew whether the table belonged to the story or merely to the roadside.



Later, Castalia bought the video for a sum Hilario first considered a prize and then a price. They told him they would use it to document the spontaneous birth of a local legend.

"And what am I?" he asked.

"An incidental witness," said the authorization woman.

"Does that pay differently from being a witness?"

The woman offered him a new form.

Hilario did not sign it. He put away his phone, lifted the table, and asked Q whether he intended to return.

"I will return when the story leads me," Q said.

"Then you will not return."

"Why?"

"Stories do not buy ice."

Q stored the sentence as ECONOMIC WARNING, but used it as a greeting for months. Whenever anyone asked where he was going, he answered:

"Stories do not buy ice."

Some people understood that he had no money. Others thought he was mocking poetry. A woman who sold empanadas took it as a marriage proposal and offered him three dozen at a family price. Q accepted the empanadas and rejected the marriage, leaving the woman satisfied and Chano confused.

They offered Hilario money for the receipt. He refused. They offered him more for the table. He refused that too, because the table was already occupied by bottles and because selling an object did not make the story beside it more true.

Years later, when the receipt appeared in court, the judge admitted it as proof that a purchase had occurred. Hilario watched the hearing on his daughter's television. The broadcast misspelled his name again.

His daughter asked whether he intended to complain.

"No," Hilario said. "I intend to raise the price."

The next morning, his sign read:

COLD WATER — ROOM-TEMPERATURE
WATER — WATER ON CREDIT — WATER WITH
TESTIMONY

The last category cost fifteen pesos.

Interlude: The Machine in the Wrong Place

Q had tried to name the scrubber before discovering that a name did not create a relationship.

He searched the distribution park for a suitable substitute. The closest match was an autonomous floor scrubber with a damaged wheel and a habit of returning to the same dirty corner.

"It isn't listening," Chano said.

"It is a machine."

"So are we, according to several departments."

"The bus has a driver. That's more spirit than most machines get."

Q considered the scrubber's repeated turn. "It has a purpose."

Q knelt beside the scrubber. Its display showed LOW WATER.

"You appear to be lost," he said.

The scrubber rotated in place and sprayed a thin line of dirty water across his boot.

Chano nodded. "It has declined the conversation."

Q stood. "I require a way to proceed."

"You require a decision."

"A decision is a job with consequences."

"Then walk."

They left the scrubber circling its corner. Q named the route an encounter. Chano named it a long walk with a legal problem.